

No, We Are Not Wrapping It Up Yet

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Essay

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Why can Gen-Z manage six group chats at once, but a ten-minute conversation with Mom and Dad feels like a hostage situation?

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The other night my wife and I sat down with our oldest son to talk about jobs.

Not a punishment talk. Not a “your grades are slipping and your mother and I are concerned” talk. Not the kind of talk where somebody has found something broken, missing, sticky, illegal, or on fire. Just a normal parent conversation about his future. Employment. Options. Different paths. Things he might want to look into. Jobs he may not even know exist yet because, shockingly, the school system has not made “guy who fixes hospital imaging machines” or “person who keeps a company’s entire computer network from bursting into flames” part of the inspirational hallway poster collection.

My wife and I were trying to be helpful.

That was our first mistake.

We were tossing out ideas, asking questions, giving examples, trying to explain that “career” does not always mean picking one thing at eighteen and then marching solemnly into a cubicle for the next forty-seven years like a condemned man with dental insurance. There are trades. There are technical jobs. There are office jobs. There are weird hybrid jobs nobody talks about until you meet someone at a cookout who says, “Yeah, I calibrate industrial food packaging sensors,” and you realize that person probably has better benefits than half the people with framed degrees and a LinkedIn banner photo of a skyline.

And while we were saying all of this, with genuine care and what I thought was maybe even a little wisdom, he gave us the look.

Parents know the look.

It is not quite disrespect. It is not open rebellion. It is not even boredom exactly. It is the face of a person waiting for a software update to finish. His eyes were still physically pointed in our direction, but the rest of him had clearly left the building. Somewhere deep inside his teenage operating system, a little spinning wheel had appeared.

Then came the hand motion.

The “wrap it up” signal.

Not in words, of course. That would require committing to the conflict. This was more of a gentle managerial gesture, like he was producing an awards show and we were the long-winded winner thanking our orthodontist, our third grade teacher, and the guy who changed our oil in 2003.

And I just sat there thinking, I’m sorry, are we boring you with the subject of the rest of your life?

To be fair, I probably did go on too long. I have the dad disease where one practical point somehow becomes seven related sub-points, a side story from 1994, and a brief lecture on why nobody knows how to shake hands anymore. I can admit that. In true Rob fashion, what started as “you should look into some different job fields” may have briefly turned into a field guide to adulthood, work ethic, benefit packages, long-term planning, and why every family needs at least one person who understands HVAC.

But still.

Ten minutes. That seems to be the modern conversational expiration date. After that, something starts happening. Tangents appear. Phones call out from pockets like haunted objects. Eyes drift. Minds fog over. Somebody suddenly needs water, food, the bathroom, a sweatshirt, a charger, or spiritual release from the terrible captivity of being spoken to by the people who pay the internet bill.

I don't remember conversations with my parents working that way.

When I was a kid, if I did something wrong, I got grilled. And I mean grilled in the way Gen-X kids understand the word. I would be standing there under what felt like an interrogation light, although it was probably just the kitchen fixture with one of those yellowish bulbs that made everyone look tired and guilty. My dad would be asking questions. My mom would be asking follow-up questions. There would be pauses. Terrible pauses. The kind where you could hear the refrigerator hum and your own future shrinking.

"Why did you do it?"

"I don't know."

"What do you mean you don't know?"

"I just don't know."

"Well, you knew enough to do it."

That line alone could trap a child for twenty-five minutes.

And I would stand there. I might shift my weight from one foot to the other. I might stare at the floor. I might wish for a sinkhole to open directly beneath the linoleum and carry me to freedom. But I would not, under any realistic circumstances, have looked at my parents and said, "Can we be done now?"

That would have been a bold legal strategy.

I am not saying our childhood was better in every way. Let's not romanticize it too much. We had lead paint, secondhand smoke, lawn darts, and parents who thought hydration was something you did if you were being dramatic. We rode in the back of trucks with no seatbelts, drank from garden hoses, and learned emotional processing from sitcom dads who solved every problem in twenty-two minutes plus commercials.

But we did understand one thing: when an adult was talking, you stood there and took it.

Maybe that was fear. Maybe it was respect. Maybe it was just the primitive survival instinct of children who knew there were no headphones small enough to hide under our hair. Whatever it was, we had some ability to remain physically present while another human being said things we did not want to hear.

That skill seems to be fading.

I am not blaming only the kids. That would be too easy, and at the end of the day, probably not fair. They did not create the world they are growing up in. We handed it to them, fully charged, algorithmically optimized, and set to vibrate. We gave them devices designed by very smart adults to make ordinary life feel slow and unbearable. Then we got irritated when ordinary life started feeling slow and unbearable to them.

A conversation with your parents cannot compete with the internet. It just can't. Your dad talking about apprenticeships does not have jump cuts, background music, captions, reaction faces, or a comment section

where strangers argue about whether electricians are secretly richer than dentists. Your mom asking what kind of work environment you might enjoy does not arrive in a thirty-second clip with a surprised man pointing at text bubbles.

Real conversation is inefficient. It wanders. It repeats itself. It makes you wait while someone finds the right words. It requires eye contact, patience, and the emotional strength to hear a sentence that is not immediately entertaining.

That is a hard sell right now.

And the really strange part is that kids today talk all the time. They are constantly communicating. Messages, snaps, memes, group chats, half-sentences, emojis, videos, shared links, weird inside jokes that seem to involve a raccoon, a distorted song clip, and a level of irony no adult can safely approach without protective equipment. They are not silent. They are not disconnected in the obvious way.

But face-to-face conversation asks something different of them.

It asks them to stay.

That is where the mind fog comes in. I see it happen. We start with a simple topic, and a few minutes later they are mentally walking through tall grass. You can almost see the attention breaking apart. One thought leads to another. Some unrelated memory pops up. A phone lights up across the room. A sibling makes a noise. A dog enters the room with the emotional urgency of a fire marshal. Suddenly the original conversation is gone, and we are somehow talking about dinner, a video game update, shoes, and whether the dog looks sad.

And sometimes I want to say, “Buddy, I am not asking you to read the collected speeches of Winston Churchill. I am asking you to follow a conversation about your own future for twelve minutes without evaporating.”

But I also remember being young and allergic to advice.

Advice from parents has always been annoying. That is not new. A parent can say the exact same thing a stranger says, and somehow the stranger sounds wise while the parent sounds like a human speed bump. When you are young, your parents’ experience feels suspicious because it comes wrapped in the same people who reminded you to wear a coat, brush your teeth, and stop leaving wet towels in a pile like you are trying to grow mushrooms.

So yes, part of this is normal.

Kids have always tried to escape parent talks. We tried too. We just had worse technology and fewer exit ramps. Our distractions were basically staring at the ceiling, picking at the edge of a couch cushion, or pretending we heard someone call us from another room. “Was that Grandma?” No, it was not. Grandma lived three towns over and had no idea you were in trouble.

Today’s kids have an entire escape ecosystem. They can disappear into a phone without moving. They can be in the same room and also not in the same room at all. They can nod while mentally checking six conversations, three videos, and a sports score. It is the miracle of modern technology: your body can remain on the couch while your attention runs away like a shoplifter.

The problem is not just that they get bored.

The problem is that boredom now feels like harm.

That sounds dramatic, but I think there is something to it. We have built a culture where every pause gets filled, every quiet moment gets interrupted, every uncomfortable silence gets medicated with a screen. Waiting in line, riding in a car, sitting at a restaurant, standing in the kitchen while your dad tries to explain career options with the passion of a county extension agent at a folding table. None of it has to be endured anymore.

And if you never practice enduring small discomforts, bigger discomforts start to feel impossible.

A long conversation is a small discomfort. Being corrected is a small discomfort. Thinking about the future is a small discomfort. Listening to advice you did not request from people who love you more than you currently appreciate is absolutely a small discomfort, with occasional spikes into moderate discomfort depending on how many examples your father uses.

But those small discomforts are where a lot of life gets built.

Work requires conversation. Marriage requires conversation. Friendship requires conversation. Parenting, God help us, requires conversations that begin with “Why is there peanut butter on the remote?” and end somewhere in the moral architecture of civilization. You cannot build a decent life entirely through reaction emojis and strategic avoidance.

At some point, somebody is going to sit across from you and say, “We need to talk.”

A boss. A spouse. A friend. A doctor. A child. A person you disappointed. A person who disappointed you. A person offering help. A person asking for honesty.

And when that moment comes, the ability to stay in the room matters.

Not just physically. Fully.

That is the serious part underneath my irritation. I am not really mad that my kid wanted the conversation to end. I get it. I have wanted plenty of conversations to end. I have sat in meetings where my soul left my body, circled the parking lot, and considered applying for work in another state. I know the feeling.

What worries me is the reflex to flee any conversation that does not provide immediate comfort, amusement, or control.

Because some of the most important conversations in life are boring at first. Or awkward. Or repetitive. Or badly timed. Or delivered by someone who means well but takes the scenic route through every point. Sometimes love sounds like a lecture because love is trying to get the words right and failing in real time.

That is easy to miss when all you feel is trapped.

I want my kids to know they have options. I want them to know they are not locked into one narrow version of success. I want them to understand that work is not just a paycheck, but it is also not supposed to be your entire identity. I want them to think about what kind of life they are building, what kind of stress they can handle, what kind of skills might give them freedom, what kind of person they want to become when nobody is handing them a syllabus.

That is a lot for a Tuesday night conversation at the kitchen table.

So maybe we need to get better too. Maybe parents need to learn the art of saying the thing before the audience files a formal grievance. Maybe every dad talk should come with a timer, a clear agenda, and a hard stop before we begin comparing 401(k)s to oil changes. Maybe we should ask more questions and perform fewer monologues. I'm with you. We can improve.

But kids need to meet us somewhere in the middle.

Not every conversation is an attack. Not every piece of advice is control. Not every uncomfortable pause is a prison sentence. Sometimes your parents are just trying to hand you a little map before you wander into the woods wearing flip-flops and carrying a phone at 12 percent battery.

We are not always right. For sure. We are often outdated, over-explaining, tired, and weirdly passionate about things like showing up five minutes early. But we are also not trying to ruin your life by talking about it.

There is a difference.

I think about those old parent lectures from my childhood now with mixed feelings. Some were too long. Some were probably unfair. Some were just adults doing their best with the tools they had, which were not always great tools. But buried inside those long, uncomfortable talks was a message I did not appreciate at the time.

You matter enough to be corrected.

You matter enough to be questioned.

You matter enough for someone to stand in a kitchen, after a long work day, and try to explain the world to you even though you are giving them the facial expression of a hostage in a low-budget training video.

That is not nothing.

Face-to-face conversation is excruciating for kids because it is slow, exposed, unpredictable, and human. There is no skip button. No mute. No scroll. No perfect response drafted and redrafted before sending. Just people, in a room, trying to understand each other with all the usual flaws, interruptions, bad timing, and over-explaining.

It is clumsy.

It is necessary.

And sometimes the most loving thing a parent can say is, "No, we are not wrapping it up yet."